

Chapter 24 - Friends

Zhou Qiongqiong led Feng Yue and Wen Zhen out of the hotpot restaurant, looking at the location she had searched up on her phone, and said happily: "There's a home furnishing lifestyle store that just opened not long ago in the mall over here. Let's go check it out."

Feng Yue and Wen Zhen saw her enthusiastic appearance and felt somewhat helpless, but in the end they still went along with her and headed toward that home furnishing store.

Throughout the journey, Zhou Qiongqiong was thinking about what exactly to buy for Feng Yue, chatting enthusiastically with Wen Zhen. Feng Yue couldn't stop her even if she tried.

"A-Yue, if you're going to shoot food videos, how about we buy you some pretty tableware? You can use it yourself normally too." Zhou Qiongqiong said while making notes on her phone.

Hearing this, Feng Yue quickly shook her head. "I already bought a batch of new ones before, specifically for shooting videos."

Zhou Qiongqiong silently pressed the delete button in her notes, thought for a moment, and said again: "Then how about buying you a soft little sofa? You can rest on it when you're tired."

Feng Yue opened her mouth wanting to refuse, but thinking about it, no matter how many times she refused, the other party would definitely still give her a gift in the end. And at this moment, Zhou Qiongqiong was obviously worrying about what to give.

Since that was the case, it would be better to just nod and agree.

Zhou Qiongqiong looked at Feng Yue, her eyes full of expectation.

Feng Yue's smile was a bit stiff at the corners, and after a while, she nodded. "That's good! My balcony area is exactly missing a small sofa!"

Wen Zhen recalled the reclining chair with a furry blanket on Feng Yue's balcony and couldn't help but feel sorry for its impending unemployment for a few seconds.

"Alright, then if we see something we like later, we'll buy it. If there's nothing satisfactory, I'll ask my friends later and bring it over for the housewarming."

Feng Yue quickly nodded in agreement.

The three came to that lifestyle store. Unfortunately, there weren't any small sofas for sale inside.

While Zhou Qiongqiong was disappointed, Feng Yue felt somewhat relieved.

However, when the three went in, they didn't buy a sofa, but when they walked out of the store, they had bought a bunch of various odd little items.

Like artistically curved glass cups, a blanket with very unique patterns, some storage boxes that looked very practical, and so on.

Feng Yue looked at the bag she was carrying and said somewhat helplessly: "So why do people go shopping? It's heavy to carry and costs money too."

Zhou Qiongqiong had bags in both hands and couldn't help her. She looked much happier than when they were eating hotpot earlier.

"Why go shopping? Of course it's because shopping brings happiness." Zhou Qiongqiong closed her eyes, tilted her head back, and took a deep breath. "Too good! Sure enough, only the happiness of shopping can eliminate the pain of dieting!"

"So why didn't you two just buy the store's delivery service while you were at it?" Wen Zhen hadn't bought anything and was currently empty-handed.

"Senior sister, you don't understand this. Shopping without carrying shopping bags—what kind of shopping is that? I might as well just shop online." Saying this, Zhou Qiongqiong also declined Wen Zhen's outstretched hand that wanted to help her carry a bag. "Go help A-Yue carry hers. Her bag is heavier—it's full of substantial stuff."

Before Feng Yue could refuse, Wen Zhen reached out and took the shopping bag from her hands, then lifted it to test the weight. "Indeed very substantial."

"I bought tableware and cups, so it's indeed heavier." Feng Yue really felt bad watching someone else carry her bag while she was empty-handed.

So she reached out to grab the other side of the bag's handle. "Let's carry it together. This way should be better."

Wen Zhen smiled and nodded. "Okay."

Actually, the distance the three had to carry the bags wasn't far—just from the fourth floor to the underground parking garage.

The mall they came to was very close to Zhou Qiongqiong's home, so as soon as Zhou Qiongqiong got in the car and before she had time to rest properly, the car had already arrived downstairs at her building.

She stood by the car carrying two bags, saying goodbye to the two through Feng Yue's rolled-down window.

"It's too late today, so I won't invite you upstairs for water. Be safe on the road." Saying this, Zhou Qiongqiong wanted to raise her hand to wave at them, but the two large bags in her hands didn't allow it, so she could only awkwardly wiggle her body at the two.

After saying goodbye to Zhou Qiongqiong, Wen Zhen dutifully drove Feng Yue home. The car stopped steadily downstairs at the residential complex, and only then did Feng Yue get out with her bag.

Seeing that she was indeed having some trouble carrying the bag, Wen Zhen said: "Do you want me to help you carry it upstairs?"

Feng Yue quickly waved her hands. "It's fine, it's fine. I can manage by myself. You've been troubled enough for one day."

"Alright, then you go up. I'll leave after I see you go in." Wen Zhen smiled.

Feng Yue nodded, said goodbye to Wen Zhen, then turned and entered the residential complex.

Wen Zhen watched her figure completely disappear from sight, then opened the storage box on her right side and took out a cigarette and a lighter.

She lit it with her hand, and immediately a somewhat strange mint scent filled the car.

Wen Zhen would usually smoke one when she felt somewhat tired, but now she wasn't tired—her mind was just a bit chaotic.

When did it start?

Probably from the moment she learned that Feng Yue and Yan Lin had divorced.

She didn't deny her admiration for Feng Yue in her heart. The other party was beautiful, had a good personality, and even shared common topics with her in cooking. All these things together were enough for her to look at Feng Yue with appreciative eyes.

Before today, she indeed hadn't had those kinds of thoughts about Feng Yue, but today, after learning that Feng Yue had divorced, those feelings that had been suppressed in her heart were inexplicably catalyzed.

However, it hadn't reached the level of "I must have her" deep feelings—probably just the state of "more than friends, not yet lovers¹."

Wen Zhen took a drag of her cigarette. The intense mint flavor filled her entire mouth, and the cool, refreshing feeling made her much more clearheaded.

Her last relationship was three years ago. Speaking of which, she had indeed been single long enough. Now that she had encountered someone who met her requirements, it was still worth trying.

By the time one cigarette had burned to the end, Wen Zhen's thoughts had become much clearer. She extinguished the cigarette butt, started the car, and then left.

After Feng Yue returned home, the first thing she did after putting down the shopping bag was to drink water and take her medicine.

Looking at the few remaining doses in the medicine box, she mentally calculated the time for her follow-up examination.

She still planned to continue receiving treatment under Professor Fang, even though that private hospital was fully funded by the Yan family. But compared to her physical health, this matter became less important.

It didn't matter whose hospital it was, as long as it could cure her illness.

After taking the medicine came Feng Yue's familiar nausea period. However, since she had been taking this medication for a while, her rejection reaction wasn't as severe as it had been initially.

She just had to endure it.

Feng Yue sorted through all the things she had bought one by one, then began arranging them in her home.

Holding the new kitchen utensils she had bought, she opened the cabinet and looked at the neatly arranged sets of kitchenware inside, then sighed deeply again.

So they shouldn't have gone shopping! She already had so many sets, yet today she couldn't help but buy another set.

However, looking at these neat, beautifully patterned tableware, Feng Yue's mood improved again.

Her original intention of going out today was to think about creative ideas for her first video. Now that the matter had been successfully resolved, she could start preparing.

She didn't have many friends and didn't need any special preparations. She just set the time and the ingredients needed for that day.

The housewarming party was tentatively set for one week later, mainly to accommodate Dai Shuangshuang, who was a student, and Zhou Qiongqiong, who was a busy dance drama actress.

Yes, Feng Yue was still planning to invite Dai Shuangshuang to this housewarming party. Setting aside her identity as Yan Lin's cousin, Dai Shuangshuang was a very good friend as a person.

Feng Yue prided herself on not being an ungrateful person. She remembered in her heart how much Dai Shuangshuang had taken care of her back then. She couldn't distance herself from her just because she divorced Yan Lin.

After planning these things, Feng Yue finally felt at ease and quietly waited for the housewarming party to arrive.

However, before the housewarming party, she was called home by her mother.

It wasn't for any other reason—the General Manager Wang² who lived next door was throwing a full moon celebration³ for his second daughter. As neighbors, the Feng family couple would naturally receive an invitation.

Originally, Feng Yue didn't have to go, but Mother Feng insisted on having her participate in more banquets to absorb some of the joyful energy from General Manager Wang's family.

Feng Yue had no choice but to reluctantly return home.

She actually didn't return home infrequently, but every time she came home, whether it was Father Feng or Mother Feng, they would seem very happy.

That evening, their family of three sat at the dinner table. The table was set with dishes all according to the menu prescribed by that nutritionist Mother Feng had hired at a high price. Just looking at it gave Feng Yue a headache.

The Feng family all had Sichuan-Chongqing⁴ tastes. Looking at this table full of bland nutritional meals, they really had no appetite.

"Mom, let's make a deal. You should just give this nutritionist to Mrs. Wang instead."

Mother Feng's face also looked a bit green looking at this table of nutritional meals, but hearing Feng Yue say this, she immediately refused seriously: "How can that be! This nutritionist is quite useful. Look, your complexion has become much more rosy than before."

Feng Yue was speechless. She couldn't tell her mother that her pale complexion before wasn't because she hadn't eaten nutritional meals, but because she was throwing up everything she ate, which made her complexion poor.

Father Feng cleared his throat lightly. "Ahem, well, it's fine for our daughter to eat nutritional meals, but we... also have to eat together?"

Hearing this, Mother Feng's expression darkened. She turned her head to glare at Father Feng. "What's wrong! For our daughter's sake, you can't even eat one meal like this?"

Father Feng was completely innocent in this disaster. He opened his mouth wanting to argue a few points, but thinking about it, decided to forget it. He honestly picked up his chopsticks and began eating slowly.

Seeing that even her father had compromised, Feng Yue had no choice but to start eating along.

Seeing this, Mother Feng's expression finally brightened.

After dinner that evening, Feng Yue returned to her room.

She was staying home tonight so it would be more convenient to attend the banquet tomorrow.

Footnotes:

¹ "More than friends, not yet lovers" (友达以上恋人未满) - A common phrase in Chinese and Japanese culture describing the ambiguous stage between friendship and romantic relationship.

² "General Manager Wang" (王总) - A respectful title for someone in a high corporate position, literally "Manager Wang."

³ "Full moon celebration" (满月酒) - A traditional Chinese celebration held when a baby turns one month old, marking their survival through the vulnerable early period.

⁴ "Sichuan-Chongqing" (川渝) - Refers to the cuisine style of Sichuan Province and Chongqing, known for being spicy and heavily flavored, contrasting with the bland nutritional meals.